

GRACE THAT GOT THERE FIRST

**(Blue denotes power point
slide)**

**(Brown denotes instruction to
technician)**

INTRO: The word prevenient comes from the word prevent, which, as it appears in the English Bible, is generally misunderstood, for we generally think of it in the sense of stopping, or hindering something. The meaning of the word prevent has been developed over the centuries since the translation of the King

James Version of the Bible.

The word prevent appears twice in the King James Version of the New Testament, neither of which has the common meaning of "*to stop*" or "*to hinder*."

The first instance is in [Matthew 17:24-25](#) (NKJV) "*And when they were come to Capernaum, they that received tribute money came to Peter, and said, Doth not your master pay tribute? ²⁵He saith, Yes. And when he was come into the house, Jesus prevented him, saying, What thinkest thou, Simon? of whom do the kings*

of the earth take custom or tribute? of their own children, or of strangers? ²⁶Peter saith unto him, Of strangers. Jesus saith unto him, Then are the children free.

²⁷Notwithstanding, lest we should offend them, go thou to the sea, and cast an hook, and take up the fish that first cometh up; and when thou hast opened his mouth, thou shalt find a piece of money: that take, and give unto them for me and thee.” The Greek word here Prophthano (pro-fa-tha-no) means "*to anticipate.*"

The second use of the word prevent is in [1 Thessalonians 4:14-15](#) (KJV) *“If we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. ¹⁵For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep.”* Here the Greek word phthano (fa-tha-no) means *“to precede, or to go before.”* Thus, the word prevent as used in the Bible means *“to act in anticipation of, or to precede.”*

Prevenient grace is that grace which goes before, and is a precursor to human involvement or action. Every believer can look back and see this prevenient grace at work in his or her life. Dr. A. H. Strong says: *“The old theologians talked of prevenient grace — grace that lays hold of us before we know it, and prepares us for the emergencies of the future.”*

Prevenient grace = Grace that got there first.

Grace:

- Was already available when man sinned... (Lamb slain from the foundation of the world)
- Furnished the strength for Noah as he built and boarded the Ark...
- Grace sustained Elijah despite the death threats and drought...
- Grace never ceased despite Samson's sin...
- Grace propelled the first century believers even though the path was difficult...

I want to make sure we
differentiate between mercy

and grace, they are two different things: Mercy is not getting what I do deserve; but grace is getting what I do not deserve!

In our culture we are conditioned to believe “*You get what you pay for.*” The thing about grace is:

- We cannot earn it...
- We cannot be good enough to deserve it...
- We cannot work hard enough to be worthy of it...
- We cannot be acquainted with enough people to negotiate it...

In Matthew's account of the dialogue between Jesus and Peter:

- Grace was present before the taxes were due...
- Grace was present when the taxes came due...
- Grace was already present even though they did not owe the taxes...
- Grace made a way where there seemed to be no way...

Isn't that the way grace always works? That's why God's grace is lovingly referred to as amazing!

Grace: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Reigned in eternity past...**
Revelation 13:8 “*Jesus was slain from the foundation of the world.*”
- **Reigns in real time... 1**
Peter 1:20 “*Jesus was foreordained from the foundation of the world but is manifest in these last times.*” In real time He is administering grace or executing it as He planned long ago!
- **Will reign in eternity to come...** “*He is from everlasting to everlasting.*”
God told Moses, “*I am that*

I am” meaning He is the one who was, is and will be. The eternal one; the self-existent one!

According to Revelation thirteen and First Peter one, there was a covenant of grace in eternity past, which is evidence of grace that got there first. If God made provision for the redemption of man before there ever was a man, then He has already taken care of tomorrow’s problems today!

CONCLUSION:

Let me close with one final scripture; [2 Corinthians 12:7-10](#)

(NKJV) *“Lest I should be exalted above measure by the abundance of the revelations, a thorn in the flesh was given to me, a messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I be exalted above measure. ⁸ Concerning this thing I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might depart from me. ⁹ And He said to me, “My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness.” Therefore most gladly I will rather boast in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. ¹⁰ Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in needs, in*

persecutions, in distresses, for Christ's sake. For when I am weak, then I am strong."

Paul's "*thorn in the flesh*" is very simple, "*A messenger of Satan sent to cause him trouble.*" Literally, everywhere he went he had a revival and caused a riot – he had problems like no-one I have ever known. Look at what the Lord said to Him "*My grace is sufficient for you, My strength is made perfect in weakness.*" Though Paul had lots of problems God was letting him know:

- Grace would be there when he arrived...

- Grace would stay as long as he was there...
- Grace would be more than enough...
- Grace would linger until he exited...

God is letting us know today:

- Grace will arrive before the crisis develops...
- Grace will remain as long as the crisis persists...
- Grace will be more than enough for the challenge...
- Grace will remain until the exit strategy has been carried out...

Think of this; Jesus left this
grace for us! It belongs to us!
It is here for us! The only
question remaining is whether
we will accept it or reject it?

Think of grace in this way:
**(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE
AT A TIME)**

- Grace covers us when we
least deserve it...
- Grace releases us from our
fiercest bondages...
- Grace opens up doors that
were permanently shut to
us...
- Grace provides a way of
escaping judgment...

- Grace intervenes when sin is present...
- Grace delivers when the enemy persists...
- Grace proves my faith and salvation...
- Grace allows me the chance at heaven...